PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Land Rover Range Rover P38A

1994–2002 · P38A

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Coolant history comes first**
  The V8's big failure is coolant loss: 4.0s usually blow head gaskets and 4.6s slip cylinder liners. The system holds roughly 11.4 litres. Check the level and condition, ask about overheating, and look up the hose and thermostat history. A properly rebuilt engine needs top-hat liners or a new block.
- [ ] **Look for a wet floor and a wet body computer**
  Damp in the passenger or driver footwell often means leaking heater matrix O-rings. Water in the cargo area or spare-wheel well points to failed tailgate seals. Remove the lower trim at the right-hand front seat (the passenger seat on US trucks) and check the Body Electrical Control Module (BECM) for water damage, because a drowned BECM is the expensive version of this problem.
- [ ] **Cycle the air suspension**
  Raise the truck to its highest setting and look at all four air springs. Listen for the compressor running constantly or cycling often, which points to leaks. An EAS warning or a lean on one corner can mean a tired height sensor. Springs are cheap from aftermarket suppliers (under £100 each), so a leak is a negotiating point, not a deal-breaker.
- [ ] **Read the HVAC display**
  A 'book' symbol on the climate-control LCD means a stored hard fault, commonly the blend motors, blower relays or A/C. Test full cold on recirculation and cycle every vent. Replacing blend motors properly means taking the dash apart, and a dealer quote can run close to $2,000.
- [ ] **Shift into low range**
  With the truck almost stopped, select low and then high again a few times. Hesitation, 'Select Neutral' or gearbox-fault messages can come from the transfer-box motor, its harness, or a misaligned XYZ gear-position switch. Listen for centre-diff clonks on tight turns.
- [ ] **Check rust where it hides**
  The panels are mostly aluminium, but rear arches are the worst cosmetic rust spot and the tailgate rusts under its plastic flap. Check the rear brake lines and look for chassis damage from off-road use.
- [ ] **Plug in a diagnostic tool**
  Check that all warning lights come on with the ignition and go out (the ABS light should go out once you drive off). A P38-capable tool such as Blackbox Solutions' Nanocom will read the EAS, BECM and HVAC fault logs that a basic OBD reader can't.
- [ ] **Petrol V8, and buy on condition**
  UK buyers' guides say choose the petrol V8 and pick on condition rather than 4.0 vs 4.6. Be wary of LPG conversions without documented professional fitting. The diesel is slow and has its own head-gasket and fuel-system issues.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Underhood hose and tubing leaks**
  1995–1998 · NHTSA 98V-149
- [ ] **Transmission breather tube icing**
  1995–1999 · NHTSA 99V-007
- [ ] **Coolant leaks near hot components**
  1995–1999 · NHTSA 00V-328
- [ ] **Throttle-body de-icer gasket**
  1999 · NHTSA 00V-329
- [ ] **Engine idler pulley**
  1999–2000 · NHTSA 00V-142
- [ ] **Transmission water contamination / park lock**
  1999–2001 · NHTSA 00V-377
- [ ] **Brake caliper bolts**
  2000 · NHTSA 00V-187
- [ ] **GEMS or Bosch**
  Open the hood. A rectangular plenum with '4.0' or '4.6' embossed in the middle means GEMS, the earlier Lucas system. A cluster of intake tubes with no label means Bosch Motronic, which arrived mid-1999. The two use different parts.
- [ ] **4.0 vs 4.6**
  The 4.6 came only with the ZF 4HP24 automatic, a 4-pin rear diff and four-wheel traction control from new. The 4.0 had the ZF 4HP22 auto or the R380 manual, and early trucks had a 2-pin diff with rear-only traction control.
- [ ] **Diesel**
  The 2.5 BMW M51 turbo-diesel (136 hp) was never sold in North America. Pre-1998 engines have an aluminium inlet manifold; later ones have EGR, a plastic manifold and a MAF sensor.
- [ ] **Factory name**
  Land Rover called it the 'New Range Rover' or the LP. 'P38A' comes from Block 38A at Solihull, where the development team was based.
- [ ] **50th Anniversary**
  The 1998 50th Anniversary trucks have Woodcote Green paint, exclusive walnut trim, colour-keyed mirrors and lower spoiler, 18-in Proline wheels and a numbered plaque. About 250 were planned.

NOTES

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